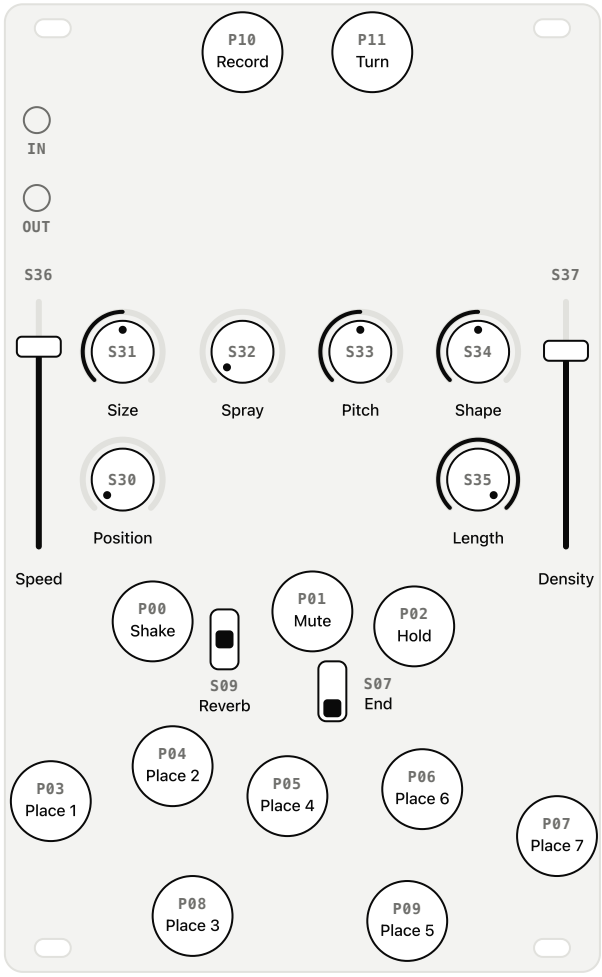
Simple Touch

Clessidra

It's the instrument where you pour grains of sound from single drops into a dense cloud.

francescodimaggio.nl/clessidra

Synthux Design Residency 2026



One layer: every control does one thing, where it is.

Record a sound: it is the sand. Speed sets how fast it runs, Density how it falls.

Density at its centre: no grains but the places'. Speed at its centre: the sand held.

FADERS AND KNOBS

S36	**Speed**. How fast the sand runs: the time stretched, the pitch kept. Held at the centre. Up forward, down reverse. Stops at ¼, ½, 1, 2 and 4×.
S37	**Density**. Grains at once, 1/16 to 16. None at the centre. Down: regular, drops to a stream. Up: random, scattered to a cloud.
S30	**Position**. Where the sand starts, anywhere in the recording. Held: moves the point.
S35	**Length**. How much sand: the selection, past the end round to the start.
S31	**Size**. Grain length, 5 ms to 2 s, 100 ms at the centre, at most half the recording.
S32	**Spray**. How far grains stray from the playhead, evenly: position, then size, pitch, pan, level, reverb send.
S33	**Pitch**. ±24 semitones. Stops at 0, 1, 3, 4, 7, 12, 24.
S34	**Shape**. The grain's window: reverse percussive down, Hann at the centre, percussive up.

PADS AND SWITCHES

S09	**Reverb**. On the grains: down off, centre short (1.7 s), up long (8 s).
S07	**End**. When the sand runs out: up stops, centre turns the glass over, down starts again.
P10	**Record**. Tap: the last 8 s. Hold: up to 30 s, the input heard. The new sand pours in over 2 s.
P11	**Turn**. A touch turns the glass over: from where it is, the sand runs the other way, the grains backwards.
P00	**Shake**. Held: the sand shaken, Spray at its top.
P01	**Mute**. Held: the grains silent, the reverb rings on.
P02	**Hold**. Held: the sand stops, the grains stay on that moment. Released: it runs on.
P03–P09	**Places**. The selection in sevenths, left to right on the board: P03, P04, P08, P05, P09, P06, P07. A touch: the playhead there, a grain at once, the beat from it. Held: it stays there.

TO PLAY

Rhythm	Density below the centre, Shape up, Size short. Tap the places: each restarts the beat
Drums by hand	Density at the centre: each place plays one grain
Cloud	Density at the top, Spray up, Size long, Reverb long
Stretch	Speed at ¼ or ½, Density up. Turn to hear it backwards
A moment held	Hold, or a place held, Density up, a little Spray, Shake for a burst

LED

Glow	Grains falling, dimmer as the sand runs out
Flashing	Recording
Pulse	At a stop: unison, speed 1× either way, 100 ms, Hann